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She shared her rental apartment in Bangalore with her co-worker at Wise. She knocked on her door, annoyed, and recalled telling her, “Your phone is ringing. Come on, pick it up or either cut it. It’s annoying.” Of course, nobody’s phone was ringing.

Her roommate later told her that she must be on the cusp of a spiritual awakening because, according to her, that is when humans feel a lot of vibrations. Wajiha didn’t give it much thought, but the spooky vibrations never stopped.

“They come out in very, very weird places,” she told. “You’re around a bunch of people, and you start saying, somebody’s phone’s ringing, somebody’s phone’s ringing, and of course, nobody’s phone’s ringing. I feel ridiculed.”

Lately, along with other people’s mobiles in her vicinity, she has also started hallucinating her own phone vibrating, sometimes twice or thrice a day. When asked how these regular phantom vibrations make her feel, to which she first chuckled, and then replied, sheepishly, “I ignore most of them. I’m like, maybe, you know, I’m just paranoid or something.”

THE PSYCHOLOGY OF AUDITORY HALLUCINATIONS

This business of hearing imaginary noises, however, is not wholly unnatural. New mothers imagine their babies crying and check on them when in fact the babies are actually asleep. And, who on Earth has ever walked on a lonely, dark, cobbled street and not thought they’ve heard unworldly, creepy noises?

As Adarsh Tripathi, assistant professor from the psychiatry department of Lucknow’s King George’s Medical University (KGMU), explained it, “If you’re walking in a calm corridor, you expect insects, and then probably even if there is nothing, your mind starts perceiving noises that insects make.”

“So people who are engaged in their mobiles, maybe expecting a call or a text or a Facebook like,” he further explained, “they at times feel

that there is a vibration or their cell-phone is ringing.”

In the scarce number of studies we have on phantom vibration syndrome, most participants say that they don’t find it much bothersome. In our teeny-tiny, very unscientific, personal sample of people hallucinating their phones buzzing; again, nobody has yet found it problematic enough to mention it to a medical professional.

However, a few studies hint at the possible adverse effects that ringxiety can cause. For starters, a study published in the Iraqi Postgraduate Medical Journal noted that phantom rings might cause discomfort or loss of concentration during driving. Phantom ringing is a Covid-19 side-effect as well, according to a May 2022 clinical study.

Last year, in the month of November, a twenty-one-year-old accountant Rupesh Mishra, who, by his own admission, gets up to ten phantom rings a day, indeed lost his control on the steering wheel. On a wintry morning, he was driving his car on NH 1, en route to Delhi from Kurukshetra, when he felt, in his phone vibrating in his pocket.

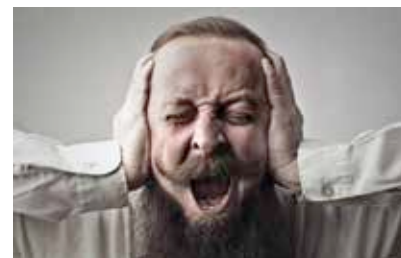
“I had not informed my father that I was going to Delhi to pick my elder brother from the airport, so I took my phone out, unlocked it, thinking he’d be the one calling,” Rupesh recalled, “but there was nothing, no one.” When he raised his eyes from his phone, he found himself – and his car – on the verge of a collision with a heavy duty truck. “I have now grown accustomed to these vibrations,” he added, “whenever I get them while driving, I try my best to ignore them. I know – most probably – they’re fake.”



IS PHANTOM RINGING A SERIOUS DISORDER?

Are phantom vibrations a cause for concern? Is it a disorder? Adarsh Tripathi had an interesting answer: One single phenomenon does not amount to normalcy or pathology. “Phantom ringing is closely linked to excessive mobile phone use,” he explained, “and nowadays doctors understand it as addiction.”

So if someone gets a phantom ring once in a while, we asked Tripathi, with a little hesitation, should they be thinking about getting a medical remedy? “No,” he replied, “unless there are things involved.” By other things involved, he meant that phantom ringing, along with excessive mobile phone usage, becomes



problematic if it starts affecting the person’s mental and physical health, and their social functioning and personal relationships.

With second-generation social entrepreneur Shrey Saxena, who runs a company that converts waste into biofuel, that was happening. Shrey was perpetually distracted at work as he always felt something was vibrating. He blocked all the notifications on his phone, but that didn’t help much until he stopped keeping his phone on vibration. The frequency with which phantom ringing used to happen drastically – and instantly – dipped.

“I also stopped using my personal phone at work and removed all social media apps from my office phone,” he told. “Now if you’d ask me when it happened last, I can’t even recall,” Shrey said, sounding victorious and relieved, proving that there is a way out. You have to find yours!